



The Illusion of Experience

By **Zhou Sijia**

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Every so often, a student comes to tell me they're planning to step away from studying for a while. They want to go out into the world, they say — to gain some real experience. There's a particular weight to the way they say it, something almost moral in the tone, as if the library has been holding them back from something more honest and more serious. I never argue with them in the moment. But a question has followed me for years, one I've turned over more times than I can count: why do we assume that lived experience is so valuable? Where did that assumption come from, and does it actually hold up?

AI gave me a way to finally think it through.

Here's a scene that has become oddly familiar. Every day, millions of people ask AI for advice on how to prepare for job interviews. This is worth thinking about carefully, because AI has never interviewed for anything. It has never

sat in a waiting room trying to look calm. It has never gone blank when a hiring manager's tone turned cold, never felt that particular sinking feeling when you realize the conversation isn't going the way you hoped, never spent the drive home replaying everything you said and everything you should have said instead. None of that has ever happened to it. It has no interview history of any kind. And yet, consistently, people find its advice organized, practical, and persuasive — often more useful, if they're honest, than advice from someone who has sat through dozens of interviews themselves.

That's worth pausing on for a moment, because it cuts against something we tend to take for granted.

Under normal circumstances, we wouldn't seek career advice from someone with no career. If a friend confessed he had never held a job, never applied for one, never even updated a resume, most of us would stop listening fairly quickly. The absence of experience would feel like a disqualifying gap. And yet AI — with precisely that gap, with no personal stake in any of it, with nothing that could be called a professional history — manages to be genuinely helpful to people navigating some of the most consequential moments of their working lives. There is a real contradiction here, and it deserves a real explanation.

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The explanation, when you look at it directly, is not mysterious: AI has read an enormous amount about interviews. Not experienced them — read about them. Its usefulness doesn't come from having been in the room. It comes from having developed a systematic, comprehensive understanding of how these situations work, what matters in them, and why. That understanding has a name. The name is knowledge. And it turns out that knowledge is doing all the persuasive work, while experience is contributing rather less than we assumed.

The obvious objection arrives quickly: AI only has that knowledge because real people with real experience wrote it all down. Everything it learned

came from someone who had actually been through something. So isn't experience still the foundation? Isn't AI just drawing on secondhand wisdom that ultimately traces back to human lives actually lived?

This sounds like a strong rebuttal. But read it again carefully, and you'll see that it has already conceded the argument.

What AI absorbed wasn't experience. It was experience that had already been transformed. Someone went through something, and then — afterward, separately, through a different kind of effort — they thought about what happened, found the right words for it, organized it into something that could be communicated to another person. By the time that material reached AI, the raw event had already been processed into something else entirely. The smelting had already happened. The original experience was just ore. The thinking and writing that came afterward — that was the actual work, the part that produced something useful.

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Raw, unexamined experience sitting in a person's memory is not knowledge. It is the precondition for knowledge, but only if someone does something with it. An unprocessed experience just sits there, private and inert, accumulating no value on its own. You can spend forty years having experiences. If you never examine them, never articulate what they taught you, never connect them to anything beyond themselves, they remain yours alone — useful to no one, eventually forgotten, contributing nothing.

When experience stays in that unprocessed state, it tends to get deployed as something other than understanding. It becomes authority. Seniority. The implicit claim that your time on earth entitles you to hold the floor. What failed to become knowledge becomes status instead. And that is where we get the line that has ended more conversations than it has ever started:

“I've crossed more bridges than you've walked roads.”

I've always found something quietly sad about that saying — not because the people who use it are unkind, but because the logic betrays them. When you

can no longer support a position with reasons, you fall back on biography. “I’ve lived through this” becomes a substitute for “here is what I understand and why, and here is how you can test whether I’m right.” The argument from experience is, when you look at it honestly, an argument that has run out of substance and is filling the gap with credentials.

There is still another layer to this, and it may be the most important one: even experience that has been genuinely processed and turned into real understanding has a shelf life.

The world changes faster now than the wisdom accumulated from a previous era can keep up with. Someone who built a career in the 1990s carries lessons and instincts shaped by conditions that no longer exist in any recognizable form. The job market they navigated, the professional hierarchies they learned to work within, the business assumptions that felt permanent to them — all of it formed in a context that has since been transformed beyond easy recognition. Their experience isn’t wrong, exactly. It’s just dated in ways they may not be aware of, because experience doesn’t come with an expiration label.

Knowledge — the kind that reaches for underlying principles, for structural patterns, for the logic beneath the surface — holds up considerably longer. Principles don’t expire with the conditions that first revealed them. But principles aren’t what you get automatically from having been somewhere or done something. They’re what you arrive at through sustained reflection. Experience is the starting point. It is not the destination.

I want to be careful here, because none of this is an argument that living through difficult things doesn’t matter. Grief changes people. Failure leaves residue. Being hurt by someone you trusted teaches you things about human nature that are very hard to arrive at through reading alone. I’m not dismissing any of that. But the value of those experiences doesn’t live in the events themselves, considered simply as events that occurred. It lives in what a person makes of them afterward — in the examination, the articulation, the slow and sometimes uncomfortable work of understanding what actually happened and what it means. Two people go through the same painful end to a marriage. One of them, over time, understands something true and lasting about how they love and why. The other accumulates a grievance and a narrative about being wronged. They had the same experience. They are not in remotely the same place.

The question has never been how much you have been through. It has always been what you took with you when you came out the other side. That thing you carry — examined, put into words, available to be applied in new situations — is knowledge. That's what actually compounds. That's what transfers.

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What I find genuinely worrying, when I look at students who spend a year in pursuit of experience, is how often they return without much to show for it intellectually. A part-time job that didn't teach much. Some social occasions that felt significant at the time and faded quickly after. Time that passed without being turned into understanding. The experiences weren't meaningless, necessarily. But they were never worked on. And the reading and thinking that didn't happen in the meantime doesn't come back.

What AI has quietly done is make visible something that was always true but easy to overlook: persuasive authority has nothing to do with having been there.

A model that has never once walked through a city can reason about urban planning with more rigor and clarity than many people who have spent their entire lives in cities. A program with no relational history whatsoever can describe the dynamics of intimacy and attachment with more precision than someone who has been in and out of relationships for decades. This isn't a paradox, and it isn't a slight against human experience. It is simply a demonstration of what experience cannot do when it remains unprocessed. Experience that gets examined and articulated becomes knowledge, and knowledge travels. Experience that stays raw remains personal, partial, and eventually disappears. It generates nothing beyond itself.

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What our moment demands is not more experience. It is the capacity to convert experience — your own and other people's — into something structured and transferable. To turn the road into a map. The tools that make this possible are reading, thinking, and writing. They are not alternatives to living; they are how living becomes usable. They are how the internal becomes legible, how the private becomes shareable, how what happened to one person in one place at one time can reach someone it was never intended for, decades later, and still mean something.

The hours spent quietly working through a difficult book are not a retreat from life. They are a form of engagement with it — a more ambitious one, in some ways, because you are not only processing your own experience but everyone else's too.

That is harder than going out and collecting time.

And over the long run, it is what actually lasts.

What do you think? [Click here](#) to leave a comment.



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